

Reflecting on Poetry

Writing a poem is one thing. Understanding how and why one wrote it is another. After drafting, after receiving feedback, after revising, the poet must take one final step: reflection. Reflection is not simply looking back at what was written. It is looking inward at the choices made, the voices that influenced those choices, and the ethical questions that arose along the way. Why did you choose that form? Which poets echo in your lines? How did you balance honesty with kindness when writing about real people? These questions transform a writing exercise into a deeper understanding of oneself as a poet.

This short reading material guides poets through reflecting on how personal voice, inspiration, and ethical considerations shape one's poetry. It also provides prompts for discussing personal insights on the craft, processes, and challenges of poetic creation.

Part 1: How Personal Voice Shapes One's Poetry

Every poet has a voice. But that voice is not fixed at birth. It emerges through practice, through reading, through revision, and through reflection. Understanding how your voice shaped your poem – and how writing the poem shaped your voice – is the first step in meaningful reflection.

What Is Personal Voice in Poetry?

Aspect	Description
Diction	The specific words you tend to choose (formal or casual, abstract or concrete)
Syntax	How you arrange words (short and direct or long and flowing)

Aspect	Description
Imagery	The kinds of images you are drawn to (urban or natural, domestic or cosmic)
Tone	Your characteristic attitude (wry, tender, angry, observant, ironic)
Subject matter	The themes and topics you return to repeatedly

Reflecting on Your Voice

Ask yourself these questions after completing a poem:

Question	What It Reveals
What words do I overuse?	Patterns in diction
What kind of images appear most often in my poems?	Your signature imagery
Is my tone consistent across my poems?	Whether you have a stable voice or are still experimenting
Would someone who knows me recognize my voice without seeing my name?	The distinctiveness of your voice
How has my voice changed from my first poem to my most recent?	Growth and evolution

The Relationship Between Voice and Form

The form you choose also expresses your voice. A poet who consistently writes sonnets may have a voice that values structure, tradition, and compression. A poet who writes free verse may have a voice that values spontaneity, natural speech, and experimentation. A poet who writes spoken word may have a voice that values performance, audience connection, and oral rhythm. Reflecting on why you chose your form reveals something about your voice.

Part 2: How Inspiration Shapes One's Poetry

No poet writes in isolation. Every poem is shaped, consciously or unconsciously, by other poems. Reflecting on your sources of inspiration – and how you transformed that inspiration into something original – is essential to understanding your creative process.

Types of Inspiration

Type	Description	Example
Direct influence	A specific poet whose work you have studied and admired	Writing a sonnet because you love Shakespeare
Indirect influence	The accumulated reading that shapes your sense of what poetry can be	Growing up reading Mary Oliver and writing nature-themed free verse
Thematic inspiration	A subject or question borrowed from another poet	Writing a poem about grief after reading Dylan Thomas
Structural inspiration	A form or technique borrowed from another poet	Using Dickinson's dashes in your own poem
Response inspiration	Writing a poem that answers or challenges another poem	Writing a poem from the perspective of the person addressed in a famous love poem

Reflecting on Your Inspirations

Ask yourself these questions:

Question	What It Reveals
Which poets did I read while writing this poem?	Direct influences
What specific lines or techniques stayed with me?	What you value in poetry
Did I borrow a form, a structure, or a move from another poet?	How you learn through imitation
How did I transform that borrowed element into something mine?	Your originality and creativity
Is there a poem I wish I had written? Why that one?	Your aspirations and values as a poet

The Difference Between Inspiration and Imitation

Practice	Description	Is It Healthy?
Imitation	Copying another poet's style without transformation	A learning exercise, not a final product
Inspiration	Absorbing another poet's techniques and making them your own	Essential for growth
Homage	Deliberately echoing another poet as a tribute	Acceptable if acknowledged

Reflection helps you recognize when you have moved from imitation to inspiration.

Part 3: How Ethical Considerations Shape One's Poetry

Poetry that draws from real life – memories, relationships, observations – carries ethical responsibilities. Reflecting on these responsibilities helps a poet grow not just as a writer but as a person.

Ethical Questions for Poets

Question	Why It Matters
Did I change identifying details to protect privacy?	Respect for real people
Would I read this poem aloud to the person it describes?	Test of kindness and honesty
Did I represent myself honestly, not as a hero or a victim?	Self-awareness and integrity
Did I avoid unnecessary cruelty or exposure?	Avoiding harm
Did I attribute any borrowed lines or images?	Honesty and academic integrity
If I used AI, did I disclose it?	Transparency

Reflecting on a Difficult Ethical Choice

If your poem involved writing about another person, reflect on that choice:

Who is the real person behind this poem?

What might they feel if they read this poem?

What details did I change to protect them?

What details did I keep? Why?

Would I make the same choices again?

The Balance Between Honesty and Kindness

Poets often struggle with a central tension: the desire to tell the truth versus the responsibility not to cause harm. Reflection helps navigate this tension.

Tension	Question to Ask
Honesty vs. privacy	Does this detail need to be here, or can I change it without losing the poem's power?
Authenticity vs. cruelty	Am I being honest or just being cruel?
My story vs. their story	Is this my story to tell?

Part 4: Personal Insights on Craft, Process, and Challenges

Beyond voice, inspiration, and ethics, poets should reflect on the practical experience of writing. What worked? What was difficult? What did you learn about yourself as a writer?

Reflecting on Craft

Craft Element	Questions for Reflection
Form	Why did you choose this form? Did it serve your subject? Would a different form work better next time?
Line breaks	Where did you break lines? Did you read the poem aloud to test the breaks? What did you learn about how line breaks affect meaning?

Craft Element	Questions for Reflection
Imagery	Where did your strongest images come from? Were they from memory, observation, or imagination?
Sound	Did you use rhyme, alliteration, or repetition? How did sound contribute to the poem's emotional effect?
Title	How did you choose the title? What work does it do?

Reflecting on Process

Process Element	Questions for Reflection
Starting	How did you begin? With an image? A line? A feeling? A question?
Drafting	How many drafts did you write? What changed between the first and final draft?
Free writing	Did free writing help? Why or why not?
Reading aloud	How did reading the poem aloud change your revision choices?
Revision	What was the hardest part of revision? What was the most satisfying?

Reflecting on Challenges

Every poet faces challenges. Naming those challenges – and how you overcame them – is a valuable part of reflection.

Challenge	Questions for Reflection
Writer's block	Did you get stuck? Where? How did you get unstuck?

Challenge	Questions for Reflection
Form constraints	Did the form feel freeing or frustrating? Why?
Emotional difficulty	Was it hard to write about certain memories or feelings? How did you manage that?
Critical voice	Did your inner critic stop you? How did you keep writing anyway?
Time	Did you have enough time to draft, rest, and revise? How did time constraints affect the poem?

What Did You Learn?

Learning Area	Questions for Reflection
About poetry	What did you learn about how poetry works?
About yourself as a writer	What are your strengths? What needs more practice?
About your voice	How would you describe your voice now compared to before?
About process	What process works best for you (e.g., free writing first, choosing form first, etc.)?
About revision	What did you learn about revising your own work?

Part 5: A Brief Reflection Exercise

After completing your poem, write a short reflection (1-2 pages) responding to **four** of the following prompts. Be specific. Refer to actual lines from your poem.

Describe your voice in this poem using three adjectives (e.g., "wry," "tender," "observant"). Where in the poem does that voice appear most clearly?

Identify one poet who influenced this poem. What specific technique or quality did you borrow? How did you make it your own?

Describe one ethical choice you made while writing this poem (e.g., changing a name, omitting a detail, deciding what to include). Why did you make that choice?

What was the hardest part of writing this poem? How did you work through it?

What line or image in this poem surprised you? Where did it come from?

If you could revise this poem one more time, what would you change? Why?

What did writing this poem teach you about poetry that you did not know before?

How did reading your poem aloud change it? What did you hear that you did not see on the page?

Sample Reflection (Annotated)

Below is a sample student reflection with annotations showing how it addresses voice, inspiration, ethics, and process.

My poem "The Wristwatch" started as a free write about my grandfather's funeral. I did not plan to write about the watch. It just appeared – the image of it still ticking on his wrist while everything else stopped. That image became the emotional center of the poem.

I realized my voice tends toward quiet observation. I do not write big dramatic statements. I write small details – the cracked leather of the watchband, the way my grandmother reached for his hand but stopped. I think I learned this voice from reading Mary Oliver. She notices things. She lets images carry emotion without announcing it.

The hardest ethical choice was whether to include my aunt's whispered comment at the funeral. It was cruel and also revealing. I kept it but changed her name and disguised her voice so no one would recognize her. I am still not sure if that was the right choice.

The biggest challenge was the ending. I wrote six different endings. None worked. Finally, I realized the poem did not need a moral or a resolution. It just needed to return to the watch. The final line is: "It is still ticking somewhere in a drawer." That line came to me while I was walking, not writing. Now I always carry a notebook.

Annotations:

Sentence from Sample	What It Demonstrates
"My voice tends toward quiet observation."	Self-awareness about voice
"I learned this voice from reading Mary Oliver."	Recognition of inspiration
"I changed her name and disguised her voice."	Ethical consideration
"I wrote six different endings."	Reflection on process and challenge
"That line came to me while I was walking, not writing."	Insight into creative process

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Personal voice	The unique combination of diction, syntax, imagery, and tone that distinguishes a poet
Inspiration	The influence of other poets or works on one's own writing
Imitation	Copying another poet's style without transformation; a learning tool, not a final product
Homage	A work written in respectful tribute to another writer
Ethical consideration	A moral question about representing real people, using sources, or disclosing AI use
Craft	The technical skills of poetry (form, line breaks, imagery, sound)
Process	The sequence of steps a poet follows from starting to revision
Reflection	Looking back on one's own writing to understand choices, growth, and challenges

Review Questions

1. Define personal voice in poetry. List three features that contribute to a poet's distinctive voice (e.g., diction, imagery, tone).
2. What is the difference between inspiration and imitation? Provide an example of each.
3. Describe one ethical question a poet should ask themselves when writing about a real person. Why is this question important?
4. What is the tension between honesty and kindness in poetry? How might a poet navigate this tension?
5. List three questions a poet can ask themselves to reflect on their revision process (e.g., "What changed between the first and final draft?").
6. What is one common challenge poets face during the writing process? Describe one strategy for overcoming that challenge.
7. Look at the sample reflection in Part 5. Identify one sentence that shows self-awareness about voice and one sentence that shows ethical consideration.
8. Reflection journal prompt (to be completed after finishing your poem): Write a 1-2 paragraph response answering four of the following questions:
 - Describe your voice in this poem using three adjectives. Where does that voice appear most clearly?
 - Identify one poet who influenced this poem. What did you borrow? How did you make it your own?
 - Describe one ethical choice you made. Why did you make that choice?
 - What was the hardest part of writing this poem? How did you work through it?
 - What did writing this poem teach you about poetry that you did not know before?
 - If you could revise one more time, what would you change? Why?